

Name: _____

Date: _____

The Door in the Orchard Wall

Year 6 reading comprehension · Story · 15 marks · About 30 minutes

Everyone in the village of Aldermere knew that the old orchard was best avoided. Its wall was crumbling and its gate had rusted shut years ago. Even the village dogs crossed the lane to avoid it. Mia had always obeyed the rule, until the afternoon she saw the door.

It was set low in the stone, half hidden by ivy: a small, round door, painted the faded blue of a summer sky. Yesterday it had not been there. Mia was certain of that.

Her fingers trembled as she pushed. The door swung inward with a groan, and a sweet smell drifted out, of apples and warm honey and something older, like rain on dry earth. Beyond it, the orchard was not the tangled wilderness she had always seen over the wall. The trees stood in perfect rows, heavy with fruit that glowed faintly, like lanterns lit from within.

“Hello?” she called. Her voice sounded small. Nothing answered, but the branches rustled softly, as if the whole orchard had drawn a breath.

She stepped inside. Behind her, the door closed with a gentle click.

Mia spun round and tugged at the handle, but the wood had vanished into solid stone. Then, from somewhere among the glowing trees, she heard a sound that made her pause: a soft, steady humming, like someone who had been waiting a very long time and had decided to pass the hours with a song.

Mia swallowed. She pressed her palm flat against the stone. It was cold and rough and utterly ordinary, as if there had never been a door at all. Somewhere above her, a single apple dropped from a branch and rolled across the grass, stopping neatly at her feet. She could stay frozen beside the wall, or she could follow the music. Slowly, she squared her shoulders and began to walk.

1. What colour was the door? (1 mark)

2. Find and copy one word from the first paragraph that tells you the orchard wall was falling apart. (1 mark)

3. The writer says Mia “had always obeyed the rule, until the afternoon she saw the door”. What does this suggest about the door? (2 marks)

4. “As if the whole orchard had drawn a breath.” What effect does this create? (2 marks)

5. Find and copy the simile that describes the fruit. What does it suggest about the fruit? (2 marks)

6. Give two ways the writer builds a feeling of mystery in this story. (2 marks)

7. Summarise what happens in this extract in no more than three sentences. (3 marks)

8. What do you think Mia will find if she follows the humming? Use clues from the story to explain your prediction. (2 marks)

Writing task: Continue the story: what does Mia find at the end of the humming?
